On time vs. In time

- **On time:** Happening exactly at the scheduled or planned time; being punctual. ("The 9:00 AM train departed on time.")
- **In time:** Happening before a deadline, or before it is too late to prevent something. ("The ambulance arrived just in time to save his life.")

In prison vs. At the prison

- **In prison:** You are locked up as an inmate serving a sentence. ("He is in prison for theft.")
- **At the prison:** You are physically there as a visitor, a lawyer, or a guard. ("She is at the prison visiting her client.")

Everyone vs. Every one: "Everyone" means all people, whereas "every one" emphasizes each individual item or person in a specific group.

- *Example:* **Everyone** enjoyed the presentation. / I thanked **every one** of the volunteers personally.

1. To vs Towards
Rule: To marks the destination that is reached; towards marks only the direction of movement, with no guarantee of arrival.
Examples with “to”: (a) The delegation travelled to Dubai for the conference. (b) The student submitted her dissertation to the examination office.
Examples with “towards”: (a) The protesters marched towards the Parliament building but were stopped at the bridge. (b) The university is moving towards a fully digital admissions system.

Wait for vs. Wait on: You "wait for" an event or person to arrive, whereas you "wait on" a customer as a server.

- *Example:* We had to **wait for** the train. / The barista will **wait on** you shortly.

On the Way

Use this phrase when talking about travel, movement, or something approaching/happening soon
Examples:

- "I am **on the way** to your house."

- "Your package is **on the way**."

In the Way

Use this phrase when someone or something is **blocking, obstructing, or hindering** progress or a path.

Examples:

- "Please move that chair, it is **in the way**."
- "My bad habits are getting **in the way** of my goals.

In the hospital

- **Meaning:** The person is **admitted as a patient** receiving medical treatment, recovering from surgery, or staying overnight.
- **Example:** *"My uncle broke his leg and is **in the hospital**."*

- At the hospital
- **Meaning:** The person is physically at the building, but not as an admitted patient. They are usually there to **visit someone**, **work** (as a doctor, nurse, or staff member), attend an appointment, or pick someone up.
- **Example:** *"I am **at the hospital** visiting my friend."* or *"She works **at the hospital**."*

- **In a car:** You use **"in"** for smaller, private, or enclosed vehicles where you simply sit down inside a tight space and cannot walk around. Examples include a car, taxi, or van.
- **On a bus:** You use **"on"** for larger public transport or vehicles that you "board" or where you have room to stand and walk down an aisle. This also applies to trains, planes, and flat vehicles you sit on top of like a bicycle or motorcycle.

What this one called?" vs "What is this one called?"

- **Rule:** A direct question needs a verb: the wh-word is followed by the auxiliary or copula (*is, are, was*), then the subject. In a passive question, the auxiliary *is* plus the past participle *called* is required.
- **Examples (direct questions):** (a) **What is** this instrument **called**? (b) **Where are** the examination results **published**?
- **Examples (embedded questions, statement order):** (a) I wonder what this one **is called**. (b) Could you tell me where the results **are published**?
- **Common mistake:** ✗ What this one called in Arabic? ✓ What **is** this one called in Arabic?

British vs American usage

- *towards* (BrE) / *toward* (AmE)
- *in hospital* (BrE) / *in the hospital* (AmE)
- *at university* (BrE) / *in college or in school* (AmE)
- *at the weekend* (BrE) / *on the weekend* (AmE)
- *Monday to Friday* (BrE) / *Monday through Friday* (AmE)
- *in a team* (BrE) / *on a team* (AmE)
- *write to me* (BrE) / *write me* (AmE)
- *different from or to* (BrE) / *different from or than* (AmE)

The seminar is **at** Oxford.	The seminar is **in** Oxford.	at → in	*At* names the institution as a venue; *in* names the city, where the venue could be anywhere.

Beside the main hall, there is a seminar room.	**Besides** the main hall, there is a seminar room.	beside → besides	Next to the hall vs in addition to the hall.
Ahmad sat **in front of** the class.	Ahmad sat **in the front of** the class.	in front of → in the front of	Before the class and facing it (outside the group) vs in the forward section of the class.
The child jumped **on** the bed.	The child jumped **onto** the bed.	on → onto	Jumping while already on the bed vs jumping from elsewhere to land on it.
The ambulance arrived **on** time.	The ambulance arrived **in** time to save him.	on → in	As scheduled vs early enough to prevent a bad outcome.
I will finish the draft **by** Friday.	I will work on the draft **until** Friday.	by → until	A deadline (no later than Friday) vs an activity continuing up to Friday.

He fell asleep **during** the lecture.	He fell asleep **while** the lecture continued.	during → while	*During* takes a noun phrase; *while* takes a clause. Mixing them gives ungrammatical sentences.

- **Contractions always have an apostrophe:** They represent missing letters (e.g., *you are → you're*, *who is → who's*, *they are → they're*).
- **Possessive pronouns never use an apostrophe:** Words that show ownership on their own do not need one (e.g., *its*, *your*, *their*, *whose*).

Common Confusing Pairs

Contraction (With Apostrophe)	Meaning	Possessive (No Apostrophe)	Meaning
it's	it is / it has	**its**	belonging to it
you're	you are	**your**	belonging to you
they're	they are	**their**	belonging to them
who's	who is / who has	**whose**	belonging to whom

The minister is **in** office.	The minister is **in the** office.	in → in the	Holds a position of authority vs is physically present in a room.

The laptop is **on** sale.	The laptop is **for** sale.	on → for	In AmE, discounted vs available to buy. (In BrE, *on sale* can also mean simply available.)